



Lifestyle Medicine

Lifestyle Medicine is a science-based approach to health that focuses on the daily choices we make – what we eat, how we move, how we sleep, manage stress, and connect with others. These habits may seem simple, but research shows they are the most powerful tools we have to prevent, treat, and even reverse many chronic conditions like diabetes, heart disease, or high blood pressure. Unlike quick fixes or one-size-fits-all programs, Lifestyle Medicine helps you get to the root of what's draining your energy, affecting your mood, or holding back your health. As a registered dietitian and certified practitioner in Lifestyle Medicine, I use evidence-based strategies to guide you in turning proven science into realistic, lasting habits that fit your life – so you can feel better, stronger, and more in control of your well-being.

NUTRITION

Fueling your body with nourishing food is not only important to provide energy for your daily activities but also the means to support the body's proper functioning. Unfortunately, many people consume a diet high in calories and low in nutrients, which can lead to sluggishness, poor mood, and even many diseases. Evidence supports the use of a whole food, plant-forward eating pattern to prevent, treat and reverse chronic illness. Choose whole plant-based foods such as fruits, vegetables, whole grains, legumes, nuts, and seeds, as they are high in fiber, antioxidants, and other nutrients.

Why it matters to you:

Eating nutrient-rich, plant-forward meals means you'll have more steady energy throughout the day, fewer afternoon crashes, and better mood balance – not just long-term disease prevention.

TIP:

Before going to eat out in a restaurant with your friends or family, search the **menu online** and take time to explore some **healthier options**. Having



time to prepare and know what to order beforehand is a successful strategy that will help you make better choices.

SLEEP

The human body simply cannot function properly and efficiently without sufficient rest. Sleep disruptions negatively influence the quality of our daily functioning, including insulin resistance, attention, mood, and even hunger. For adults, 7-9 hours of uninterrupted sleep per day is vital for physical and mental health. Some of the most common disruptors of sleep quality include caffeine consumption, blue light exposure, stress, and noise.

Why it matters to you:

Quality sleep isn't just about feeling rested – it's the secret to sharper focus, fewer cravings, more patience, and better overall resilience in your day-to-day life.

TIP:

Underestimating the power of basic sleep rules can turn against us. When it comes to good sleep, make sure that you follow these simple and well-known rules: Comfortable **room temperature**, no **blue-light** emitting technology or **beverage consumption** 1-2 hours before bedtime, and the use of **blackout curtains** and **earplugs**.

PHYSICAL ACTIVITY

Movement is another area that helps to achieve and maintain optimal functioning. All of the body systems, such as for example skeletal, muscular, endocrine, cardiovascular, and respiratory benefit from physical activity. A sedentary lifestyle has a negative effect on our bodies and is associated with risk for many diseases. Because of the detrimental effects physical inactivity has on our bodies, it's been determined that 'sitting is the new smoking!'



Regular exercise consisting of **aerobic, strength, and flexibility training** is essential not only for optimal physical but also mental well-being!

Why it matters to you:

Regular movement keeps your body strong, your energy stable, and your mood lifted – making everyday tasks easier and helping you feel more confident in your body.

TIP:

Taking at least **7000 steps each day** has been proven to lower mortality rates. You don't need to purchase any special or expensive electronic devices to measure your step count. Did you know that most smartphones nowadays have sensors that track your steps automatically? Look up instructions on how to access the **step count on your phone** and start tracking!

STRESS MANAGEMENT

While some stress can help to enhance our productivity and performance, many daily stressors cause the opposite. With high stress levels, we can observe an increase in risk for diseases, anxiety, depression, and even our weight. In the Lifestyle Medicine Program, we learn about and apply **stress reduction techniques** for improved well-being. Some of the proven techniques include journaling, breathing exercises, and meditation.

Why it matters to you:

Managing stress helps you think more clearly, sleep more deeply, and enjoy your day with less tension – so you can show up as your best self for work, family, and yourself.

TIP:

When feeling stressed, close your eyes and take a moment to try the **4-7-8 breathing method**. It consists of the following:



- 4: Breathe in through your nose on the count of 4.
- 7: Hold your breath and count to 7.
- 8: Exhale through your mouth to the count of 8.

SUBSTANCE USE

Avoid tobacco, excess alcohol, and other risky substance use, as it has been shown to increase the risk of not only chronic diseases but even death. Treatments for substance use take time and consists of many different approaches. Finding the right support and practicing patience and kindness to yourself are the keys to successfully reaching your goals. Some effective treatment models include counseling and/or medication.

Why it matters to you:

Reducing alcohol, tobacco, or other substances doesn't just add years to your life – it improves your energy, sleep, and mood almost immediately.

TIP:

Start making changes in your substance use by setting a **SMART goal**. The acronym SMART stands for Specific, Measurable, Attainable, Realistic, and Time-Relevant.

HEALTHY RELATIONSHIPS

Social connectedness is one of the most essential predictors of our happiness. It directly affects our physical, mental, and emotional health. Strong social connections help to not only improve the quality and length of our life but also measures such as heart rate and blood pressure.

Why it matters to you:

Strong connections don't just make you happier – they lower stress, boost your immune system, and even support a healthier heart.



TIP:

If you want to build new friendships or perhaps just meet new people with similar interests as you, try searching for social events on your local social media groups or for example public library boards.